

Logical Positivism — MCQ Questions

54-question closed-book practice bank · no answer key

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MCQ 1

Which description correctly identifies the 1929 Vienna Circle manifesto?

A. Schlick alone authored the manifesto as the Circle's binding verificationist creed. B. Ayer issued the manifesto in Britain after publishing *Language, Truth and Logic*. C. Hahn, Neurath and Carnap wrote the manifesto and dedicated it to Moritz Schlick. D. Wittgenstein and Popper jointly issued the manifesto as a programme of falsification.

MCQ 2

Which membership and influence statement is accurate?

A. Schlick, Carnap and Neurath were central Circle figures, and Ayer and Wittgenstein were influential non-members. B. Ayer founded the Vienna Circle, while Schlick later introduced its programme to Britain. C. Wittgenstein chaired the Circle and co-authored its scientific-worldview manifesto. D. Popper and Quine were Circle members who progressively weakened the verification principle.

MCQ 3

To call philosophy a 'handmaid to science' in the positivist programme is primarily to assign it the task of:

A. Philosophy should collect laboratory observations overlooked by the specialist sciences. B. Philosophy should derive scientific laws from self-evident metaphysical principles. C. Philosophy should replace scientific theories with ordinary descriptions and reject formal reconstruction. D. Philosophy should clarify scientific language and logic rather than add rival factual discoveries.

MCQ 4

Which influence map avoids collapsing distinct sources into a single doctrine?

A. Mach supplied empiricism, Frege and Russell modern logic, Einstein an operational model, and early Wittgenstein logical-form themes. B. Mach supplied formal logic, Einstein emotivism, and Wittgenstein the strong-weak distinction. C. Russell supplied protocol coherentism, Neurath picture theory, and Schlick falsifiability. D. Kant supplied physicalism, Hegel supplied verification, and Popper supplied the analytic-synthetic distinction used by the Circle.

MCQ 5

The verification principle first asks whether a declarative sentence:

A. A declarative sentence is meaningful only when current scientific opinion accepts it as true. B. A declarative sentence is meaningful when its grammar is elegant, its vocabulary is familiar, and ordinary speakers accept it. C. A declarative sentence is meaningful when it is analytic or open to possible empirical

testing. D. A declarative sentence is meaningful when it expresses an attitude approved by most people.

MCQ 6

Why is 'The earth is flat' different from 'The Absolute is beyond every possible experience' on the positivist test?

A. The flat-earth claim is analytic, and the Absolute claim is a weakly confirmed law. B. The flat-earth claim is meaningful and false, and the Absolute claim excludes every possible empirical test. C. Modern science has empirically falsified both claims in precisely the same way. D. Both claims are meaningful because each contains a familiar grammatical subject.

MCQ 7

Which classification follows the positivist two-route account of cognitive meaning?

A. A tautology and a metaphysical assertion are equally meaningless because neither reports an observation or predicts an event. B. A moral command is analytic, and a scientific report has merely emotive significance. C. A tautology is analytically meaningful, while a contingent report is meaningful through possible experience. D. Every grammatically complete sentence possesses cognitive meaning regardless of its empirical role.

MCQ 8

When positivists call ethics, ritual or poetry 'cognitively meaningless', the careful interpretation is that such language:

A. Such language is unintelligible noise that competent speakers cannot understand or use. B. Such language is empirically false because scientific observation directly contradicts it. C. Such language becomes meaningful only after translation into an analytic tautology. D. Such language states no verifiable fact and may retain expressive, practical or aesthetic significance.

MCQ 9

A proposition is verifiable in the strong sense when:

A. Strong verification requires evidence that changes a proposition's probability without settling it. B. Strong verification requires coherence with a theory even when no observation bears on it. C. Strong verification requires one possible falsifier and requires no confirming observation. D. Strong verification requires a finite set of observations that conclusively establishes truth.

MCQ 10

Ayer's weak sense counts a proposition as verifiable when:

A. Weak verification requires possible experience that raises or lowers a proposition's probability. B. Weak verification requires the proposition's denial to contradict the rules of language. C. Weak verification requires direct observation of every instance covered by a proposition. D. Weak verification requires scientists to adopt the proposition as a useful framework rule.

MCQ 11

Before spacecraft could inspect it, 'There are mountains on the far side of the Moon' remained meaningful because:

A. The lunar claim was analytic because mountains belong to the definition of the Moon. B. The lunar claim followed logically from the positivist programme for unifying science. C. The lunar claim needed no possible evidence because scientists already considered it probable. D. The lunar claim specified a possible observation even before that observation was practicable.

MCQ 12

What best distinguishes direct from indirect verification in Ayer's revised discussion?

A. Direct verification applies to analytic truths, and indirect verification applies to moral claims. B. Direct verification is conclusive, and indirect verification necessarily establishes falsity. C. Direct verification is private, and indirect verification is always a public convention. D. Direct verification links a claim to observation immediately, and indirect verification uses auxiliary premises.

MCQ 13

Why do unrestricted scientific laws create trouble for strong verification?

A. Universal scientific laws are analytic conventions whose necessity comes entirely from stipulated linguistic definitions. B. No finite collection of observations can establish every observed and unobserved instance of a universal law. C. Universal scientific laws are metaphysical simply because they employ general terms. D. A single counter-instance verifies a universal law by decisively testing its scope.

MCQ 14

Which chronology of Ayer's criterion and Church's criticism is correct?

A. Ayer revised the criterion in 1936, Church answered it in 1946, and the original Language, Truth and Logic appeared in 1949. B. Church proposed strong verification in 1936, and Ayer replaced it with falsifiability in 1949. C. Ayer published his criterion only after Church had already demonstrated its formal defect. D. Ayer's first edition appeared in 1936, his revised Introduction in 1946, and Church's objection in 1949.

MCQ 15

What is the force of Church's 1949 objection to Ayer's revised test?

A. Church proved that observations cannot support even singular empirical statements. B. Church showed that analytic truths become synthetic whenever they enter arguments containing empirical auxiliary premises. C. Church showed that suitable conjunctions let arbitrary propositions satisfy Ayer's revised criterion. D. Church established falsifiability as a definition of meaning equivalent to verification.

MCQ 16

Schlick's difference-argument most directly supports the claim that:

A. The difference-argument requires every meaningful statement to have been conclusively verified. B. Hypotheses with no possible observational difference lack a difference in cognitive content. C. The difference-argument establishes that only physicalist vocabulary is intelligible. D. The difference-argument requires science to eliminate every theoretical entity.

MCQ 17

Einstein's influence on the Circle is most carefully stated as follows:

A. Relativity proved that every meaningful sentence reduces to one speaker's private sensations. B. Relativity modelled procedural clarification of simultaneity without proving a universal theory of meaning. C. Special relativity established the analytic-synthetic distinction and made scientific conventions unrevisable. D. Einstein's physics supplied Ayer with the emotive analysis of ethical language.

MCQ 18

Which presupposition is directly destabilised by the Schlick–Neurath protocol debate?

A. The protocol debate destabilises the synthetic a priori by treating all necessary truths as reports of immediate experience. B. The protocol debate concerns whether metaphysical entities occupy space and time. C. The protocol debate establishes that falsifiability and verifiability are identical. D. The protocol debate destabilises belief in a neutral, epistemically privileged observation language.

MCQ 19

Duhem–Quine holism challenges sentence-by-sentence verification because:

A. Holism holds that observation can never rationally influence any scientific belief. B. Holism holds that scientific laws are analytic commitments immune to revision. C. Holism holds that predictions confront experience with auxiliaries and a wider theory, not in isolation. D. Holism confines background assumptions to metaphysics and lets scientific predictions face observations alone.

MCQ 20

What exactly changes when the Circle moves from the *Tractatus* to verificationism?

A. The Circle simply renamed Wittgensteinian objects as Neurathian protocol sentences. B. The Circle added an epistemic demand for verification conditions to a logical account of truth-conditions. C. The *Tractatus* already contained Ayer's 1946 direct-indirect criterion in its final form. D. The Circle abandoned logical form and replaced it with Hegelian dialectical development.

MCQ 21

Which sequence accurately represents the *Tractatus*-to-positivism historical line?

A. The *Tractatus* appeared in 1921/22, the Circle read it in 1926-27, conversations followed in 1929-32, and Ayer published in 1936. B. The manifesto appeared in 1918, the *Tractatus* in 1929, Ayer published in 1932, and the conversations began in 1946. C. Ayer published in 1921, the Circle read him in 1936, the manifesto appeared in 1949, and Church joined the conversations in 1951. D. Wittgenstein joined the Circle in 1926, Popper led it in 1929, and Quine wrote its manifesto.

MCQ 22

Which statement best preserves Wittgenstein's institutional boundary?

A. Wittgenstein founded the Vienna Circle and appointed Schlick as its official spokesman. B. Wittgenstein co-authored the manifesto and adopted Neurath's physicalist protocol language. C. Wittgenstein influenced Schlick and Waismann and remained outside the Circle. D. Wittgenstein developed the strong-weak terminology that Ayer later popularised.

MCQ 23

How should the contrast over ethics between the *Tractatus* and Ayer be expressed?

A. Both early Wittgenstein and Ayer reduce ethical utterances to reports of private psychology. B. Early Wittgenstein places value outside factual saying, and Ayer treats moral utterances as non-cognitive expressions. C. Both early Wittgenstein and Ayer treat ethical claims as weakly confirmed scientific hypotheses about observable conduct. D. Ayer preserves ineffable ethical truths in exactly the form proposed by the *Tractatus*.

MCQ 24

Carnap recognises two principal ways in which a pseudostatement may arise:

A. A pseudostatement arises whenever a proposition is false, lacks conclusive evidence, or awaits improved scientific instruments. B. A pseudostatement arises whenever a sentence expresses emotion or employs a metaphor. C. A pseudostatement arises whenever a claim is universal or contains a theoretical term. D. A

pseudostatement arises whenever a term lacks application criteria or a combination yields no truth-conditions.

MCQ 25

Carnap's diagnosis of Heidegger's 'Nothing noths' focuses on:

A. Carnap diagnoses 'nothing' as a naming subject joined to a pseudo-verb, with surface grammar masking logical failure. B. Carnap treats 'Nothing noths' as an empirical claim about anxiety that later observation refuted. C. Carnap derives the defect in 'Nothing noths' solely from the law of excluded middle. D. Carnap treats 'Nothing noths' as a legitimate analytic definition of non-being.

MCQ 26

Why is 'Caesar is a prime number' a useful diagnostic example?

A. The Caesar sentence is a false historical report that Roman records can disprove. B. The Caesar sentence is an analytic contradiction equivalent to 'Caesar is not Caesar'. C. The Caesar sentence is a scientific generalisation awaiting archaeological confirmation about Roman mathematical practices. D. The Caesar sentence is a category error combining familiar words without coherent verification conditions.

MCQ 27

In the 2023 meaning–knowledge–reality question, the best ranked verdict is that rejection of metaphysics is:

A. The rejection is primarily semantic, grounded in empiricist assumptions and consequential for ontological discourse. B. The rejection reports the empirical discovery that all metaphysical entities fail to exist. C. The rejection merely repeats Kant's epistemic limit on things in themselves and leaves the cognitive meaning of metaphysics intact. D. The rejection presents meaning, knowledge and ontology as unrelated problems of equal priority.

MCQ 28

Which treatment of a transcendent theological claim is most faithful to Ayer's criterion?

A. Science conclusively falsifies a transcendent claim by observing every possible region of reality. B. A believer's definition makes a transcendent existence-claim analytic, necessary, and cognitively meaningful without observation. C. A transcendent factual claim lacks possible empirical conditions, and its ritual or expressive uses require separate analysis. D. A transcendent claim becomes weakly verified whenever belief in it provides psychological comfort.

MCQ 29

Which set contains an analytic claim, an empirical claim and a positivist pseudostatement, in that order?

A. The sequence is empirical, analytic and empirical, namely 'The road is wet', 'All bachelors are unmarried' and 'Electrons carry negative charge'. B. The sequence is metaphysical, analytic and empirical, namely 'God is transcendent', 'Two plus two equals four' and 'The page is white'. C. The sequence is analytic, empirical and metaphysical, namely 'Either it rains or not', 'The road is wet' and 'The Absolute is beyond testing'. D. The sequence is evaluative, metaphysical and empirical, namely 'Pain is unpleasant', 'Reality is spiritual' and 'Some metals conduct electricity'.

MCQ 30

On Ayer's emotivism, saying 'Stealing is wrong' differs from saying 'I disapprove of stealing' because the former:

A. The moral utterance describes a non-natural property known through ethical intuition. B. The moral utterance expresses disapproval without reporting the speaker's psychological state. C. The moral utterance states an analytic definition of the action called stealing. D. The moral utterance predicts that every competent listener shares the speaker's feeling and will display the same conduct.

MCQ 31

Stevenson's account goes beyond Ayer chiefly by emphasising:

A. Stevenson proves that moral predicates denote objective properties whose descriptive content settles disagreements in attitude. B. Stevenson denies the possibility of moral debate once disagreement about facts has ended. C. Stevenson reduces ethical meaning to strong verification through observable behaviour. D. Stevenson combines descriptive and emotive meaning with disagreement in attitude and persuasion.

MCQ 32

Which contrast about moral argument is accurate?

A. Ayer limits rational dispute mainly to facts, and Stevenson lets reasons and persuasive definitions redirect attitudes. B. Ayer treats moral conclusions as scientific laws, and Stevenson excludes persuasive definition from genuine ethical discussion. C. Ayer and Stevenson both classify value judgements as truths fixed by linguistic definition. D. Stevenson reduces every ethical disagreement to autobiographical reports about private feelings.

MCQ 33

The Frege–Geach problem pressures simple emotivism because:

A. The Frege-Geach problem arises because a moral sentence keeps inferential content inside an unasserted conditional. B. The Frege-Geach problem claims that ethical sentences cannot be translated into ordinary language without losing their emotive force. C. The Frege-Geach problem establishes that moral predicates always name natural properties. D. The Frege-Geach problem denies that disagreement in attitude can survive factual agreement.

MCQ 34

A careful analysis of 'The Soul of Superman is Good' should separate:

A. The sentence requires a distinction between scientific falsification and analytic contradiction. B. The sentence combines a subject-reference problem with a non-descriptive evaluative predicate. C. The sentence combines a weakly verified subject with a strongly verified moral property. D. The sentence requires valid existential quantification followed by a colour observation.

MCQ 35

The linguistic theory of necessary propositions explains necessity by claiming that logic and mathematics are:

A. Logic and mathematics are analytic consequences of linguistic rules and therefore add no empirical facts. B. Logic and mathematics are synthetic a priori truths imposed by the mind upon experience. C. Logic and mathematics are inductive generalisations that future observations may overturn. D. Logic and mathematics are intuitive insights into independently existing abstract objects grasped without linguistic conventions.

MCQ 36

Which comparison among Kant, Mill and the positivists is correct?

A. Kant and Mill make mathematics analytic, while positivists classify it as synthetic a priori. B. Kant defends synthetic a priori necessity, Mill gives an empirical account, and positivists make necessity linguistic. C. Mill grounds necessity in rational intuition, and Kant derives it from repeated observation. D. Kant, Mill and the positivists all explain mathematical necessity by reference to an independently existing supersensible realm.

MCQ 37

For logical positivists, 'All objects are either red or not red' and 'This page is white' are:

A. Both sentences are empirical because each contains a predicate referring to colour. B. Both sentences are analytic because neither sentence can possibly be false. C. Both are meaningful, with the first analytic and tautological and the second empirical and contingent. D. The first sentence is meaningless, and one colour observation conclusively verifies the second with certainty.

MCQ 38

How do positivists most plausibly preserve the meaning of a general scientific law?

A. A general law remains meaningful through weak or indirect tests of its observational consequences. B. A general law remains meaningful only after being redefined as an analytic convention. C. A general law remains meaningful only after every possible instance has been observed. D. A general law remains meaningful as emotive guidance rather than as a truth-apt assertion.

MCQ 39

Why need theoretical entities not be meaningless under a developed positivist account?

A. Theoretical entities are analytic definitions whose truth is immune to scientific revision. B. Theoretical entities are equivalent to transcendent beings because neither is directly visible. C. Theoretical entities gain empirical significance through laws and observable consequences of a theory-system. D. Theoretical entities possess meaning only when they are directly visible to unaided perception.

MCQ 40

Which contrast between phenomenalist reconstruction and physicalist language is accurate?

A. Phenomenalism reconstructs object-talk from experience, and physicalism seeks a public intersubjective language. B. Phenomenalism and physicalism are interchangeable names for private, incorrigible sense-data. C. Phenomenalism is Popperian falsificationism, and physicalism is Quinean holism applied to a common scientific vocabulary. D. Physicalism requires protocol sentences to be fixed permanently and protected from revision.

MCQ 41

The unity-of-science project is best described as an attempt to:

A. The unity project replaces the sciences with one comprehensive metaphysical account of reality. B. The unity project deduces every scientific law from a single privileged protocol sentence. C. The unity project coordinates scientific claims in a public language and permits disagreement about reduction. D. The unity project eliminates logical syntax so that each science can retain private meanings.

MCQ 42

Schlick's 'affirmations' in the protocol debate were intended as:

A. Schlick's affirmations are fallible physical reports revised solely to preserve systemic coherence. B. Schlick's affirmations are immediate here-now acts where understanding and verification coincide. C. Schlick's affirmations are analytic framework rules selected for their practical convenience. D. Schlick's affirmations are universal laws verified through an infinite series of observations.

MCQ 43

Neurath's protocol sentences and boat image jointly express the view that:

A. Neurath grounds protocol sentences in private, incorrigible experiences that supply a foundation outside every linguistic system. B. Neurath treats observation reports as public and fallible, revised aboard a system with no external foundation. C. Neurath's boat requires one final metalanguage capable of validating every scientific language. D. Neurath holds that coherence alone guarantees truth without empirical or practical constraint.

MCQ 44

Carnap's 1932 intervention in the protocol dispute proposes that protocol form is:

A. Carnap fixes protocol form through private sensation and excludes every later reformulation. B. Carnap lets Popper's falsifiability criterion determine the uniquely correct protocol form. C. Carnap treats protocol form as a choice of linguistic system rather than a uniquely given foundation. D. Carnap holds that reality fixes one uniquely correct protocol form independently of linguistic choices or pragmatic purposes.

MCQ 45

Carnap's Principle of Tolerance means that:

A. Tolerance makes every proposition true whenever a speaker chooses a language containing it. B. Tolerance permits alternative logical languages when their rules are explicit and their adoption is pragmatically assessed. C. Tolerance converts all ethical judgements into empirically verifiable factual propositions. D. Tolerance treats logical rules as metaphysical objects discovered independently of language and binding every possible framework.

MCQ 46

Carnap classifies 'Is there a prime number above 100?' and 'Are numbers really real?' respectively as:

A. Carnap treats the prime-number question as external and the reality-of-numbers question as an internal theorem. B. Carnap treats both questions as empirical problems settled by direct sensory observation. C. Carnap treats the prime-number question as internal and theoretical, and framework adoption as external and practical. D. Carnap treats both questions as meaningless because neither refers directly to physical matter.

MCQ 47

Quine's pressure on Carnap's framework distinction is strongest when he argues that:

A. Quine argues that framework choice is impossible because every meaningful language shares one invariant and unrevisable logical syntax. B. Quine argues that holism and doubts about analyticity weaken Carnap's insulated internal-external boundary. C. Quine argues that internal questions become meaningless whenever they quantify over abstract entities. D. Quine argues that Carnap's tolerance principle entails Kant's doctrine of the synthetic a priori.

MCQ 48

The self-application objection says that the verification principle:

A. The principle is neither analytic nor empirically verifiable and therefore fails its own criterion. B. The principle is empirically false because one decisive experiment directly refuted it. C. The principle is an analytic tautology whose denial produces a formal contradiction. D. The principle is simply another formulation of the logical law of non-contradiction.

MCQ 49

If verification is defended as a recommendation for using 'meaningful', the immediate cost is that:

A. The recommendation avoids direct self-refutation without gaining power to compel rival linguistic practices. B. The recommendation becomes an empirically verified law describing actual speaker behaviour. C. The recommendation proves metaphysical claims false rather than cognitively meaningless. D. The recommendation becomes a Neurathian protocol report of a present observation.

MCQ 50

Why do statements about the past create a problem for strict verificationism?

A. Past-tense claims are analytic because calendars and dates are linguistic conventions. B. Present records make past events directly observable by reproducing their original circumstances. C. Past-tense claims are necessarily metaphysical because their events no longer occur. D. Present traces can support past claims indirectly, and present evidence is not identical with the past event described.

MCQ 51

The other-minds problem pressures verificationism because:

A. Other minds are analytic entities introduced by convention into a public language. B. Every speaker directly observes the private experiences of every other person. C. Popper's falsifiability criterion makes private mental-state claims both unscientific and meaningless by definition. D. Behaviour supplies public evidence for another mind and may not preserve the full claim about experience.

MCQ 52

Popper's falsifiability differs from verificationism because it is offered as:

A. Falsifiability distinguishes scientific from non-scientific theories without declaring all metaphysics meaningless. B. Falsifiability requires conclusive positive proof before a general law counts as scientific. C. Falsifiability is an analytic convention that converts metaphysical systems into sciences. D. Falsifiability is the Vienna Circle's unanimous definition of protocol statements and their relation to universal scientific laws.

MCQ 53

Which comparison best captures Quine and later Wittgenstein as bounded critics?

A. Quine defends strong verification, and later Wittgenstein formalises Carnap's logical syntax. B. Quine and later Wittgenstein were Circle members who authored its compromise on protocols. C. Quine and later Wittgenstein preserve one universal empirical criterion governing scientific, ethical, religious and mathematical uses. D. Quine attacks analyticity and isolated testing, and later Wittgenstein replaces one essence of meaning with plural use.

MCQ 54

Why did the positivist attempt to make philosophy a handmaid to science and create a unified language ultimately fail?

A. The programme failed because the Circle abandoned formal logic and adopted speculative idealism. B. The programme failed because scientific laws, protocol disputes, theory-ladenness, holism and contested analyticity fragmented it. C. The programme failed because every science rejected public testing and all shared terminology. D. The programme failed because Popper verified metaphysics, disproved every universal law, and replaced logic with historical conjecture.